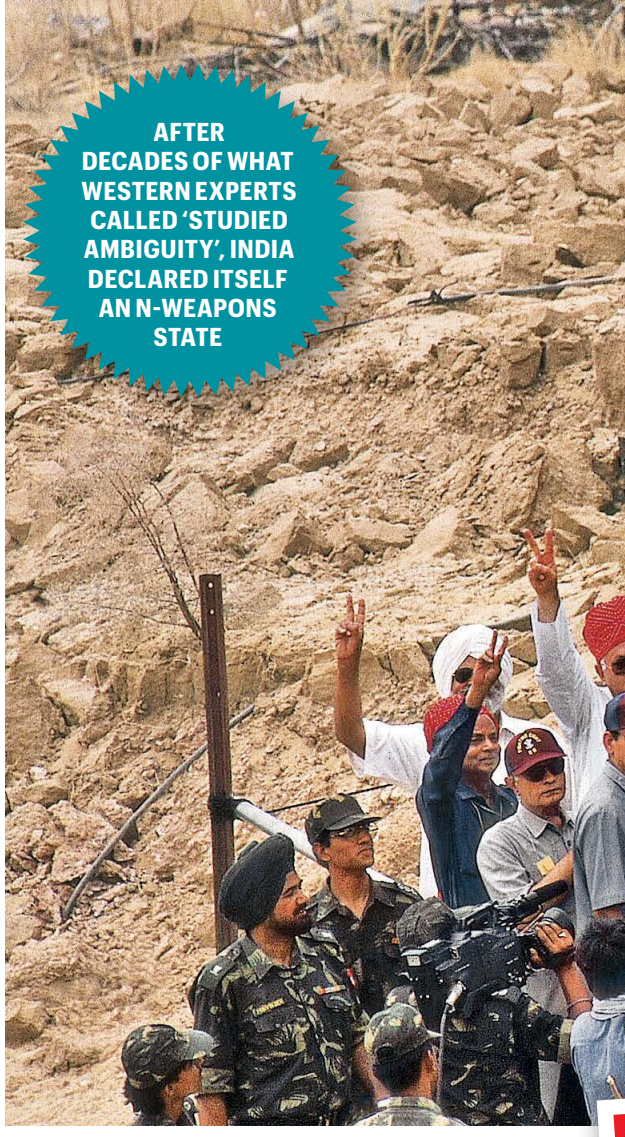
50TH ANNIVERSARY
1995-2005

| SECURITY |

THE NUKE SHIELD

Pokhran-II announced India as a nuclear weapons state. It did bring in some recriminations and sanctions, but India shrugged it off. It was now a bona fide member of the nuclear club



PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

The blasts were loud, the aftermath sent a few more reverberations. In May 1998, India conducted its second series of nuclear tests at the Pokhran test range in the Rajasthan desert. Pokhran-II detonated five devices deep underground at a designated site, setting off a chain of strategic and diplomatic consequences for the country.

Domestically, the N-tests ticked all the boxes for Prime Minister A.B. Vajpayee and the BJP, in their second attempt at leading a coalition formation. The new government basked in the popular approval; it had managed a feat the Congress and ex-PM Narasimha Rao could not (having had to back down under US pressure in 1995). 'Operation Shakti' also fed into the saffron party's broader narrative—recasting India as a muscular, self-reliant, rising power. Needless to say, it also helped in the 1999 general election, which finally brought the BJP to power for a full term.

On the international stage, after decades of what western experts called 'studied ambiguity', India declared itself a nuclear-weapons state. In its defence, it cited an unforgiving, nuclear-armed neighbourhood—China to the north and Pakistan in the west. A 'credible deterrent', India argued, was essential and non-negotiable.

The international community didn't buy it, and sanctions followed, led by the US and Japan. India found itself diplomatically isolated. Aid turned into a trickle, loans were curtailed, but the Indian economy

The Bomb Makers
Jun. 22, 1998

"By noon, the wind still hadn't abated and the outside temperature was a searing 43 degrees Celsius. R. Chidambaram, Atomic Energy Commission (ABC) chairman, dressed as Major-General Natraj, removed his Gorkha hat to stop the sweat from streaming down his face. On his left, A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, scientific adviser to the defence minister and chief of the DRDO , also incognito, sat impassively.

For Operation Shakti, as the tests were called, Kalam was known as Maj. Gen. Prithvirai. But the mane of silvery white hair that stuck out incongruously from his hat was a dead giveaway. All this was